area east of the Mediterranean in which to station reserves for the Middle and Far East'.[47]

The 1939 Committee tried to meet prominent Indian politicians to obtain their views on military expenditure and role of the military. The Indian National Congress rebuffed the meeting request whereas the Muslim League met with the committee. The committee's report thus stated, 'If a Hindu majority came to power, it would drastically change military policy since defence strategy and expenditure would leave British hands for the first time.' [48] This view that the 'Hindu' Congress would be worse for British interests than the 'Muslim' League influenced British views of the Indian independence struggle and how British officials viewed the future.



Belief in India as the springboard for security of regions to its west and east had resulted in a British project, beginning in the eighteenth century, to create closer ties between the Persian Gulf and India. From 1763, civilian and military officers of the East India Company helped control and administer the Gulf for the British. From 1824 onwards these officers reported to the political resident in the region, who was always an officer from the British Indian services. Hence, India was 'the base' for the British both in times of peace and war and 'stability' in the Middle East 'rested' on British rule over an undivided India.[49]

The reasoning that India was necessary for Britain, and the Far and Near East were important for India's security, permeated the thinking of British officials at almost all levels. It also affected the foreign policies of both India and Pakistan after Independence. In his book *Wells of Power: The Oilfields of South Western Asia: A Regional and Global Study*, British Indian civil servant Sir Olaf Caroe echoed Curzon and Churchill. He argued, in the context of the cold war pitching the West against communist Russia, that control of India (and Pakistan, after Partition) was critical to